N-gram Hints in Language Model Training: Stopping Them From Leaking Answers or Blocking Reasoning

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Abstract

An n-gram hint tells a language model which token most often followed the last n tokens in the training data. Hints recently cut the NanoGPT Speedrun record from 39.9 s to 6.7 s. The hints used during training come only from tokens trained in earlier steps, because a large corpus from the start makes the model rely on hints too much. We test this choice on a small character-level transformer trained with Muon. Keeping a token's own occurrence in the counts is the failure to avoid: validation loss goes from 1.89 to 3.53. Removing only that occurrence and dropping half of the hints at random during training gives a loss of 1.80 against 1.89 for hints from earlier steps, and this gap held at about 0.08 across a 15-fold range of model size. The gap grows when the corpus is much larger than the tokens trained (0.37 at 40 times) and disappears when it is 2.5 times larger. We did not reproduce on Shakespeare the reported result that each doubling of the corpus helps more than the last. On web text, leaving out the token's whole page removes the harm at small corpora, and short matches give most of the gain, which shrinks with training. In a made-up language, hints give perfect recall of facts stored in the same words and nothing for other wording, and hints added at the input stop the model from learning two-step comparison and sums. Hints added only at the output, with half dropped, keep the recall and restore that learning. When one model trains on web text and these tasks together, hints at all three places block comparison at three model sizes, while output-only hints keep it at the cost of part of the web text gain. The code is public [17].

1 Introduction

Language models learn slowly from text they have seen only a few times, and web text is full of passages that repeat only occasionally. Brunborg [1] uses this: during training, idle CPUs build a corpus that records which tokens follow each n-gram. The model receives the most common next token as a hint and learns how much to trust it. The record went from 39.9 s to 6.7 s [2]. The blog post reports two things that matter for this paper. A large hint corpus from the start makes the backbone rely on the hints too much, so training uses a small corpus and validation a large one. And each doubling of the corpus cuts the loss more than the last [1].

The record's code computes training hints in a strictly causal way: a step's hints count only tokens trained in earlier steps [3]. That has a cost. At validation the model meets hints from a far larger corpus than any it trained with, so it must trust counts it has never seen.

This paper asks one question: if a language model is trained with Muon, can it use hints from the whole corpus from the first step, without the failure the blog post describes, and is that better than hints from earlier steps? We make three contributions.

1. We show that a token's own occurrence in the counts is enough to break training with a full corpus.

2. We show that removing it, plus random hint dropout, beats causal hints at three model sizes.

3. We measure how the gain depends on the ratio of corpus size to tokens trained.

4. We test what hints help, facts or reasoning, and find that where hints enter the model decides whether it can still learn to reason.

2 Background

Muon. Muon [4] is an optimizer for the matrices of a network. It keeps momentum, replaces the update with its nearest orthogonal matrix using Newton-Schulz steps, and moves the weights by a fixed step. Its use at large scale is studied in [5]. Wang et al. [6] find that Muon learns rare classes better than Adam, which is the same rare-data problem hints address. Embeddings stay on Adam, as is standard.

Memory by lookup. Engram [7] adds hashed n-gram embedding tables whose vectors are learned, and Tensorizing Engram [8] and Lngram v2 [9] extend this line. Hints differ: nothing is learned per n-gram, and the corpus stores only the next tokens. RETRO [10] retrieves whole text chunks from a very large database.

Leakage. A count feature that includes the row's own label leaks the label. Target encoding for categorical features has this problem [11]. CatBoost [12] calls the result prediction shift and fixes it with ordered statistics, which use only earlier rows. That is the same idea as causal hints. Leave-one-out statistics are the other common fix. RETRO applies the document-level version: it filters out neighbours from the same document as the training sequence [10], so removing the token's own occurrence is not a new idea in retrieval. Our searches found no paper comparing causal and leave-one-out hints for n-gram hints, and none using hint dropout. Dropping an input at random so a model does not rely on it follows dropout [13].

3 Method

Model. We use the Muon lab model [14]: a character-level transformer on Tiny Shakespeare with RoPE, QK-norm, RMSNorm, a SwiGLU MLP, no biases and tied embeddings, with 4 layers and 4 heads. The first 90% of the text is the training split. Muon trains the hidden matrices with momentum 0.95, and Adam trains the embeddings and norm weights at 0.003. Training has 20 warmup steps and a linear cooldown over the last 30%.

Hints. We follow the blog post, with lengths 6, 12 and 24 characters in place of 6, 10 and 20 tokens. For each length the hint is the most common next character. Its count falls into one of 7 buckets and its purity (the share of the n-gram's occurrences followed by that character) into one of 6, giving 126 kinds. Each kind has a learned amount σ and a learned vector β. The hint vector is

$$H_t = \sum_n \big(\sigma_{k(n,t)}\, E[\mathrm{hint}_n(t)] + \beta_{k(n,t)}\big), \tag{1}$$

where E is the embedding table. We add H_t after the embedding, after layer 2 and before the output head, each with its own learned scale. The hint parameters use Adam at 0.03.

Training hint policies. Validation always uses the whole training split as its corpus. Training uses one of these:

- **None:** no hints.
- **Own token kept:** the whole training split, with each token's own occurrence still in the counts.
- **Earlier steps:** only tokens trained in earlier steps, as in the record.
- **Leave-one-out:** the whole training split with each token's own occurrence removed. If removing it leaves no count, there is no hint, exactly as for an unseen n-gram at validation.
- **Leave-one-out with dropout:** the same, and each hint is dropped with probability 0.5.

Training streams shuffled, non-overlapping chunks of 65 characters, so a token appears at most once per pass. The default batch is 8 and the default length is 200 steps, or 102K trained tokens. The corpus is 1.0M characters, 10 times the tokens trained. The record's ratio is about 520 times [1], which a 1 MB text cannot reach.

Measurement. Each setting was run once at Muon learning rates 0.01, 0.02 and 0.04, and we report the best. Validation uses 96 fixed chunks. Before running, we predicted that own-token-kept would be worst, leave-one-out best, and that hints would make the model worse when they are switched off.

4 Results

4.1 Keeping the token's own occurrence breaks training

Table 1 shows the results at width 64. The predictions held. With the token's own occurrence in the counts, every training n-gram has a match, and a long n-gram usually has only that one occurrence, so the hint is the answer. The model learns to trust hints it will not get at validation. Its loss with hints is 3.53, far worse than 2.16 with no hints at all. Removing that one occurrence brings the loss to 1.84.

Training hints	Validation, hints on	Validation, hints off
None	–	2.165
Own token kept	3.525	4.735
Earlier steps	1.890	2.307
Earlier steps, half dropped	1.860	2.204
Leave-one-out	1.843	2.508
Leave-one-out, quarter dropped	1.800	2.349
Leave-one-out, half dropped	**1.805**	**2.256**
Leave-one-out, three quarters dropped	1.807	2.206

Table 1: Width 64, 200 steps, batch 8. Best of three learning rates by loss with hints.

4.2 Hint dropout removes most of the reliance on hints

Leave-one-out alone makes the backbone worse when hints are off: 2.508 against 2.165 with no hints. This matches the blog post's report of relying on hints too much. Dropping half of the hints brings this to 2.256 and also lowers the loss with hints from 1.843 to 1.805. Dropping a quarter gives a similar loss with hints (1.800) with a worse backbone (2.349), so we use one half. Dropout also helps earlier-steps hints (1.890 to 1.860), but they stay behind.

4.3 The gain stays the same as the model grows

Table 2 shows a gap between 0.070 and 0.085 across a 15-fold range of parameters. The best learning rate stayed at 0.01 or 0.02 at each size for each policy, so hints did not move Muon's best learning rate in this range.

Width	Parameters	No hints	Earlier steps	Leave-one-out, half dropped	Gap
32	56K	2.317	1.938	1.858	0.081
64	209K	2.165	1.890	1.805	0.085
128	812K	2.085	1.840	1.769	0.070

Table 2: Validation loss with hints on, 200 steps, batch 8, corpus 10 times the tokens trained.

4.4 The gain depends on corpus size divided by tokens trained

Table 3 changes the tokens trained at width 32 with the corpus fixed. The gap is 0.370 at a ratio of 40, 0.081 at 10 and 0 at 2.5, because hints from earlier steps approach the whole corpus as training goes on. At 3200 steps the stream starts a second pass, so hints from earlier steps contain each token's own earlier occurrence. This is the failure from Section 4.1 again: loss rises to 2.533, while leave-one-out reaches 1.603. Causal hints are safe only within one pass.

Steps	Batch	Ratio	No hints	Earlier steps	Leave-one-out, half dropped	Gap
200	2	40	2.534	2.386	2.016	0.370
200	8	10	2.317	1.938	1.858	0.081
800	8	2.5	1.956	1.676	1.676	0.000
3200	8	0.6	1.755	2.533	1.603	0.930

Table 3: Width 32, hints on. Ratio is corpus size divided by tokens trained. The last row is past one pass over the data.

4.5 Each doubling of the corpus

We first evaluated models with the first N characters of the training split. The last doubling then gave a gain of 0.237 against 0.09 or less for each earlier one, which looks like the reported acceleration. The last part of the corpus is, however, the text next to the validation split, and the jump disappears when the corpus is sampled evenly. With random 256-character pieces instead, the gains per doubling are 0.040, 0.052, 0.050, 0.060, 0.099, 0.062 and 0.061 for leave-one-out with dropout, and 0.053, 0.055, 0.052, 0.060, 0.073, 0.028 and 0.018 for earlier steps (Figure 1). Neither curve shows gains that rise with each doubling, so we did not reproduce the blog post's result. The

share of validation characters with a hint rose from 15% to 79%. In the earlier-steps model the loss on hinted characters stops falling after 251K characters (1.74, then 1.75 and 1.77), about 2.5 times its tokens trained, because it never learned how much to trust larger counts. In the leave-one-out model it keeps falling to 1.66.

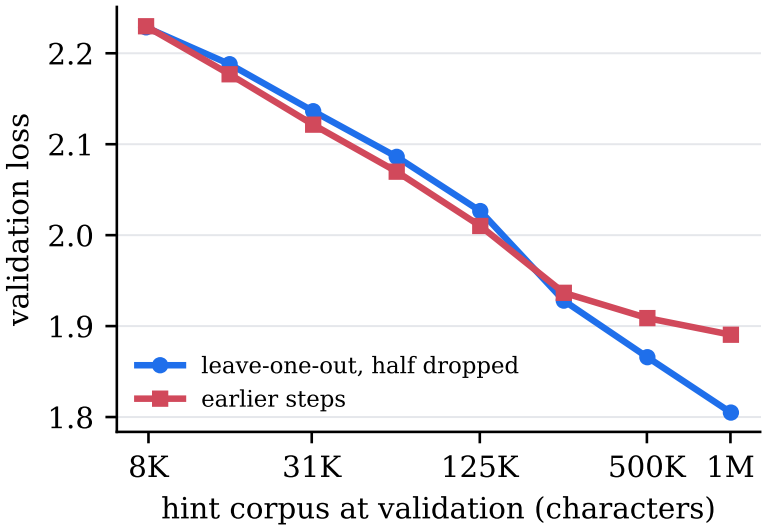


Figure 1: One final model of each kind evaluated with random subsets of the corpus. Width 64, 200 steps.

5 Web Text

We repeated the test on FineWeb [1], using GPT-2 tokens from one 100M-token training shard as the corpus and text from the separate validation shard. Corpus sizes are prefixes of the shard, from 0.78M to 100M tokens. All training chunks lie inside the smallest corpus. The model has width 40, 4 layers, about 1.4M parameters, batch 8 and 90 steps (46K trained tokens) unless stated, with 256 validation chunks. Hints use lengths 6, 10 and 20 tokens unless stated; the longest set adds 2, 3, 4 and 5. Each setting was run once, at the learning rates above unless stated.

5.1 The hints improve with each doubling on web text

Before any model is involved, the share of validation tokens where the hint is right grows faster with each doubling (Table 4). This matches the blog post's report for the hints, unlike our Shakespeare result. We did not check the cause. Near-duplicate pages in both shards are one possibility.

5.2 Leaving out the whole page removes the harm on small corpora

Validation loss without hints was 7.871. Removing only a token's own occurrence does harm below 25M tokens: hinted tokens score 9.62 at 0.78M and the overall loss is 7.877. Removing every match from the token's own page removes this harm. At 100M the loss is 7.816 with the page left out and no hints dropped, against 7.821 with one occurrence left out and half of the hints dropped. At 50M the page version is 0.003 worse (7.842 against 7.839). With the page left out, dropping half of the hints no longer helps at 100M (7.825). Training hint shares then match validation for 6-grams

Corpus	Any hint	Hint right	Added by this doubling
0.78M	0.42%	0.13%	
1.56M	0.63%	0.20%	0.07%
3.1M	0.91%	0.28%	0.08%
6.25M	1.30%	0.38%	0.11%
12.5M	1.83%	0.58%	0.19%
25M	2.65%	0.89%	0.31%
50M	3.64%	1.35%	0.46%
100M	5.01%	2.06%	0.71%

Table 4: Hints of lengths 6, 10 and 20 on 65K validation tokens, with no model. "Hint right" is a share of all tokens.

(4.98% and 5.01%) but not for 20-grams (0.77% and 0.31%), so same-page repeats do not explain all extra long matches.

5.3 Short matches give most of the gain, and that gain shrinks with training

Adding matches of 2, 3, 4 and 5 tokens raises the share of tokens with a hint from 5% to 92% and gives by far the largest drop. Loss falls with every doubling of the corpus, from 7.741 at 0.78M to 7.244 at 100M, with gains between 0.045 and 0.107 that rise unevenly. Most of this comes from lengths 2 and 3: at 100M, length 2 alone gives 7.373, and length 4 and longer gives 7.696.

Table 5 shows what happens with longer training at corpus 100M, with learning rate 0.02. The gain from short matches falls from 0.63 to 0.34 over 16 times more training, because the model learns common next tokens by itself. The gain from lengths 6, 10 and 20 stays between 0.04 and 0.07. The model that uses all seven lengths depends on them: with hints off it scores 7.754 against 6.916 at the longest run.

Steps	Tokens trained	No hints	Lengths 6, 10, 20	All seven lengths
90	46K	7.871	7.816	7.244
360	184K	7.398	7.333	6.879
1440	737K	6.916	6.872	6.580

Table 5: Validation loss at corpus 100M. Hints leave out the token's own page. The vocabulary grows with the steps (28,359, 39,394 and 46,243 tokens), so compare within a row.

Starting the hints with trust above zero helps a little and did not hurt on small corpora when the own page is left out: at 100M with all seven lengths the loss falls from 7.244 at a starting trust of 0 to 7.197 at 4, the largest value tried, which suggests 90 steps are too few to learn trust.

6 Facts and Reasoning

Engram [7] reports gains on reasoning benchmarks as well as knowledge benchmarks, with learned tables. Wang et al. [15] find that factual questions correlate with n-gram memorization and reasoning tasks with generalization, and Norlund et al. [16] find that RETRO's gains largely come from tokens shared with the test data. We found no test of retrieved next-token hints by task kind, so we built a language where the kind of each answer is known.

Setup. The corpus holds 1.5M lines of made-up text: rare facts stated 3 times each, common facts stated 300 times, sums modulo 10 with 20 of 100 pairs held out, two-step comparisons with fresh names, and reading an answer from the line. Hints use lengths 2, 3, 4 and 6, leave out each token's own occurrence, and enter after the embedding, after layer 2 and before the output head. The model has width 64 and 4 layers, and trains for 5760 steps of 32 lines at learning rate 0.02. We test 1000 new lines per group. Chance is 1% for facts, about 10% for sums and 50% for reading and comparison, where always picking the first name scores that much.

Hints	Common	Rare	Other words	Not in table	Held-out sum	Read	Comparison
None	.995	.009	.005	.013	.492	.480	1.000
All 3 places	1.000	1.000	.010	.004	0	.502	.495
All 3 places, half dropped	1.000	1.000	.006	.012	0	.513	.495
Input only	1.000	1.000	.006	.012	0	.513	.497
Length 6 only, all 3 places	1.000	1.000	.012	.010	.730	.474	.499
Output only	1.000	1.000	.010	.003	0	.924	1.000
Output only, half dropped	**1.000**	**1.000**	**.006**	**.012**	**.536**	**.499**	**.999**

Table 6: Accuracy at the answer token.

Results. Table 6 shows that hints take rare facts from chance to 100% when the test uses the stored words, and give nothing when the words change or the fact is absent. Hints at all three places stop the model from learning comparison (.495 against 1.000) and held-out sums (0 against .492). Hint dropout alone does not fix this. Hints only at the output restore comparison but not sums. Length 6 alone restores sums but not comparison. Output only with half dropped restores both and keeps all recall. As a labelled guess, a hint at the input lets the model skip learning the task, and a confident wrong hint at the output overrides a right answer unless dropout teaches the model to doubt it. Neither arm learned the reading task except output only at .924, which we cannot explain, so it says little.

This does not contradict Engram: its tables are learned, while our hints are retrieved next tokens. A made-up language shows a mechanism, not its size in real models.

6.1 Web text and reasoning in one model

Next we trained one model on both languages at once: each step uses 2 web chunks and 32 made-up lines, for 5760 steps. The two languages share no tokens, so one joined hint table gives the same hints as two separate tables. Each language's loss covers only its own tokens, for speed. Web hints use all seven lengths and leave out the token's page, with corpus 100M. We predicted that output-only hints with half dropped would keep at least two thirds of the web text gain, and this failed.

Table 7 shows a trade-off. Hints at all three places give the largest web text gain, 0.28 to 0.31, and block comparison at all three sizes; with hints off their web loss is about 0.65 worse than no hints. Output-only hints keep comparison and keep 41% of that gain at width 64 and 64% at width 96. Dropping half restores held-out sums too and leaves the hints-off web loss equal to or better than no hints, but keeps only 12%, 7% and 33% of the gain at widths 32, 64 and 96. The share kept is highest at the largest size, but these are single runs at three sizes spanning 3.2 times the parameters, or 9 times without the embedding table.

Width	Hints	Web, hints on	Web, hints off	Held-out sum	Comparison
32	None	–	7.132	.493	.600
32	All 3 places	6.824	7.846	0	.496
32	Output only, half dropped	7.095	7.107	.458	.929
64	None	–	6.991	.350	.971
64	All 3 places	6.714	7.637	.048	.496
64	Output only	6.878	7.061	0	1.000
64	Output only, half dropped	6.971	6.991	.267	.995
96	None	–	6.956	.484	.981
96	All 3 places	6.677	7.602	0	.495
96	Output only	6.777	6.988	0	.995
96	Output only, half dropped	6.863	6.942	.434	.996

Table 7: One model trained on web text and the made-up language. Accuracy at the answer token. Rare facts in the table scored 1.000 in every hint row.

7 Limits

- The made-up language tests use one training length, so they have no length check. Facts runs took about 190 s and joint runs 537 to 888 s, over our usual 10 s limit. We did not split the web text gain by token kind.
- The web text models stop at a loss far above real models, so they do not show what hints do for a trained model. The 360-step and 1440-step runs took 59 to 214 s, and web runs at 90 steps took up to 11.3 s, over our usual 10 s limit.
- Shakespeare is not web text. It has no crawled duplicates, its tokens are characters, and 6-grams match 79% of validation but carry little information. The blog post's rising returns may need exact duplicates at long n-grams, so this does not contradict it.
- Each setting was run once, and learning rates were picked on the same validation chunks used for reporting, for every arm alike.
- The 800-step, 3200-step and width-128 runs took 11 to 97 s, over our usual 10 s limit. The batch of 53 runs that included them took 3 minutes 18 seconds on 8 cores.
- The ratio in Table 3 changes together with tokens trained, so we did not measure a fixed ratio at longer training.
- Our model trains no more than 1.6M characters, far from a real run, and we did not test the corpus sizes at which a hint table stops fitting in memory. In a real run, leave-one-out needs the full corpus before training starts, or a table large enough to subtract one count per lookup.

8 Open Questions

Each question below can be tested without the others.

1. If a GPT-2-sized model is trained with Muon on web text, does adding n-gram hints from the training data lower validation loss compared with the same model trained without hints?

2. If a model much larger than GPT-2 is trained on web text, do n-gram hints still lower validation loss by a useful amount compared with the same model without hints?

3. If a model is trained on web text with hints, does each doubling of the hint corpus lower validation loss by more than the doubling before it, even after near-duplicate documents are removed from the training data?

4. If a model is trained on web text with a hint corpus about 500 times larger than the tokens it trains on, does removing each token's own occurrence and dropping half of the hints give lower validation loss than using hints from earlier steps only?

5. If a model keeps using a hint table when it answers, how much of the loss gain is lost when the table is cut from 352 GiB to 1% of that size by keeping only the most common n-grams?

6. If a model is trained with hints, does it repeat training text word for word more often than the same model trained without hints, both with the hints on and with them off?

7. If two models are tested on rare facts that appear only a few times in the training data, does the model with hints answer more of them correctly than the model without hints?

8. If a model is tested on text that shares no documents with the training data, do hints still lower its loss compared with the same model without hints?

9. If the ratio of hint corpus size to tokens trained is held fixed while training gets longer, does the gain from removing each token's own occurrence and dropping half of the hints stay the same?

9 Planned Experiments

The small models above have not learned common next tokens, so we plan these experiments next.

1. If the n-gram table predicts each validation token on its own, with no model, is its loss lower than the 7.24 of the small model that uses hints?

2. If the model receives the table's counts for all next tokens as additions to its output scores, instead of the embedding of the most common next token, is its validation loss lower?

3. If the vocabulary is cut to the 2,000 most common tokens plus one token for all others, so that each step is faster, does a model given the same time reach a lower validation loss, measured against the same model without hints at that vocabulary?

4. If a model trains far beyond 16 times longer than our first web text run, does the validation loss gain from short matches disappear?

5. If a model with hints at the output is made much larger, does the share of the web text loss gain it keeps, compared with hints at all three places, keep rising?

6. If the web text loss gain is split by the longest match of each token and by token kind, do names and numbers gain more than other tokens only when the match is long?

10 Conclusion

For hints from a full corpus, remove each token's own occurrence (on web text, its whole page), and drop half of the hints during training. If the model must also learn to reason, add hints only at the output: in a made-up language this kept perfect recall of stored facts and restored comparison, which hints at all three places blocked at every size we tried. This costs part of the web text gain, so it is a trade-off, and dropping half of the hints restores sums too at a larger cost. In a small Muon-trained model this beat hints from earlier steps by about 0.08 at three sizes, and by more when the corpus was far larger than the tokens trained. If a run makes more than one pass, causal hints need the same removal. As a labelled guess, the size of this gain at the record's ratio of about 520 could be larger than in our 40 times case, but web text may behave differently, so it must be tested on FineWeb.

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